

- *Woman's Hour* is the cornerstone of the BBC Radio 4 weekly schedule, with new episodes being broadcast every day at 10am for an hour. There is also an omnibus edition broadcast on a Saturday afternoon at 4pm.
- All episodes of the programme are also available as podcasts on BBC Sounds.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media industries

Historical Contexts:

Woman's Hour was first broadcast in the 1940s, so it's worth considering the **historical and social shifts** that have occurred since the show's inception. The original show could be said to reflect **tokenism** (a show set aside for women might imply all other radio content was oriented towards men). However, this format has continued and has developed into an important part of Radio 4's schedule.

Consider the specialised and institutionalised nature of media production and the significance of economic factors to media industries and their products:

- The BBC is the most-used brand in the UK for media. 'It is used by 90% of UK adults and 80% of young adults on average per week. Used by an average of five million adults every single minute of the day and night, across TV, radio and online, and by a total of 45 million people across all ages over 24 hours.'
(<https://downloads.bbc.co.uk/aboutthebbc/reports/annualreport/2020-21.pdf>)
- The BBC is a **public service broadcaster (PSB)** and has a remit to **inform, educate and entertain**. Consider whether *Woman's Hour* is typical of products created for BBC Radio along with what makes a programme distinctively a Radio 4 broadcast.
- It is significant and of continued debate that the BBC is funded by the **licence fee**, a very different funding model from commercial radio that relies on advertising and sponsorship. In 2022, the debate about the licence fee was heightened when Culture Secretary Nadine Dorries announced that the licence fee would be frozen for the next two years,

effectively forcing the BBC to make cuts to their programming. There is a demand in some quarters of government for the licence fee model to be reviewed. Others stress the importance of maintaining an independent, impartial broadcaster that is not under pressure to appeal to advertisers. The BBC is considered by many to be a pillar of British life – a reliable and trustworthy source, particularly in the days of 'fake news', whose high-quality products are exported globally.

- Programmes like *Woman's Hour* may be deemed too 'niche' and specifically targeted for commercial radio. The broadcast has largely female contributors, is predominantly made up of unadorned dialogue (without music, sound effects etc.) and the topics are explored using intellectual and specialised vocabulary. Consider why commercial institutions would be less likely to produce similar products.

Consider recent technological change and media production, distribution and circulation and the impact of digitally convergent media platforms:

- The programme and its **podcasts** offer a number of ways to explore recent changes to the radio industry in relation to digital technology, such as the profound changes that have been brought about by switching from **analogue FM** radio to **digital audio** broadcasting (DAB), and the boom in downloading and streaming.
- A significant recent change that has impacted the radio industry is podcasting and listening to broadcasts on **digitally convergent** platforms such as computers and smartphones. In November 2018, the BBC launched BBC Sounds, a **walled garden** streaming service featuring live broadcasting, audio-on-demand and podcasts. This a good example of **technological convergence** as Sounds is available on PCs, laptops, tablets and phones. The slogan 'Listen without Limits' reflects the fact that the way in which the BBC distributes its content has changed in order to address developments in technology and audience consumption of content.